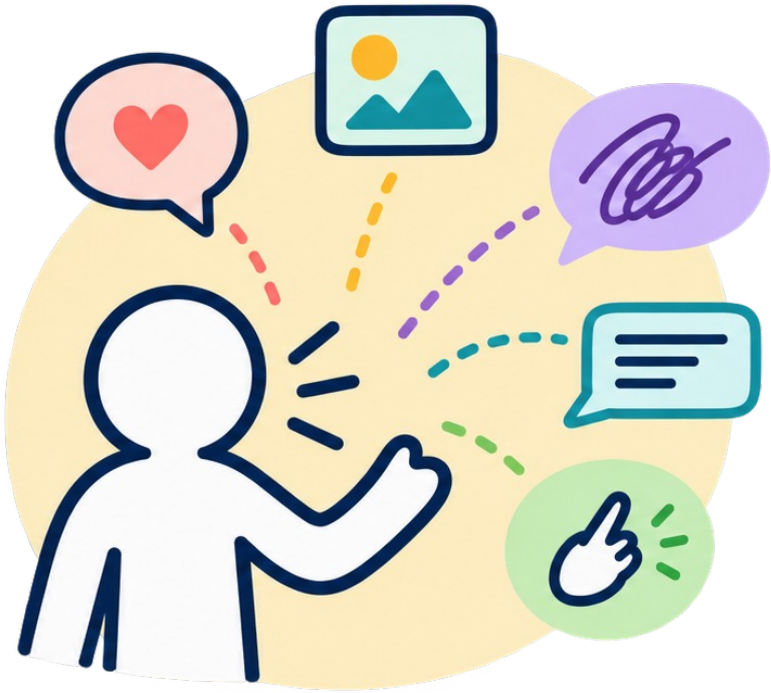




Primary Education · Session 3

Autistic Experience at the Primary School:

**Communication, Connection
and Identity**



Communication





Understanding and expressing

How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.

Understanding

Information coming in

Spoken words



Visual or written



Demonstration



Gesture and context



Expressing

Messages going out

Speech



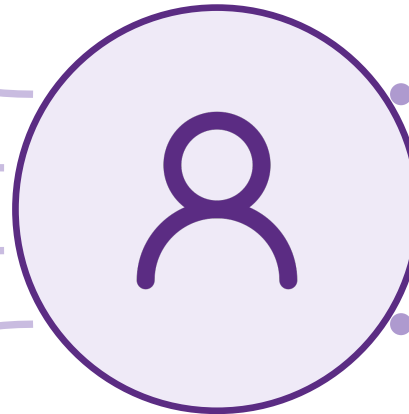
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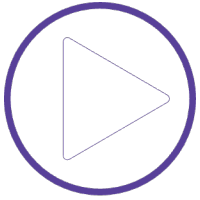


Writing or typing



Gesture, sign and movement





Communication experiences

What stood out to you about what supported communication?



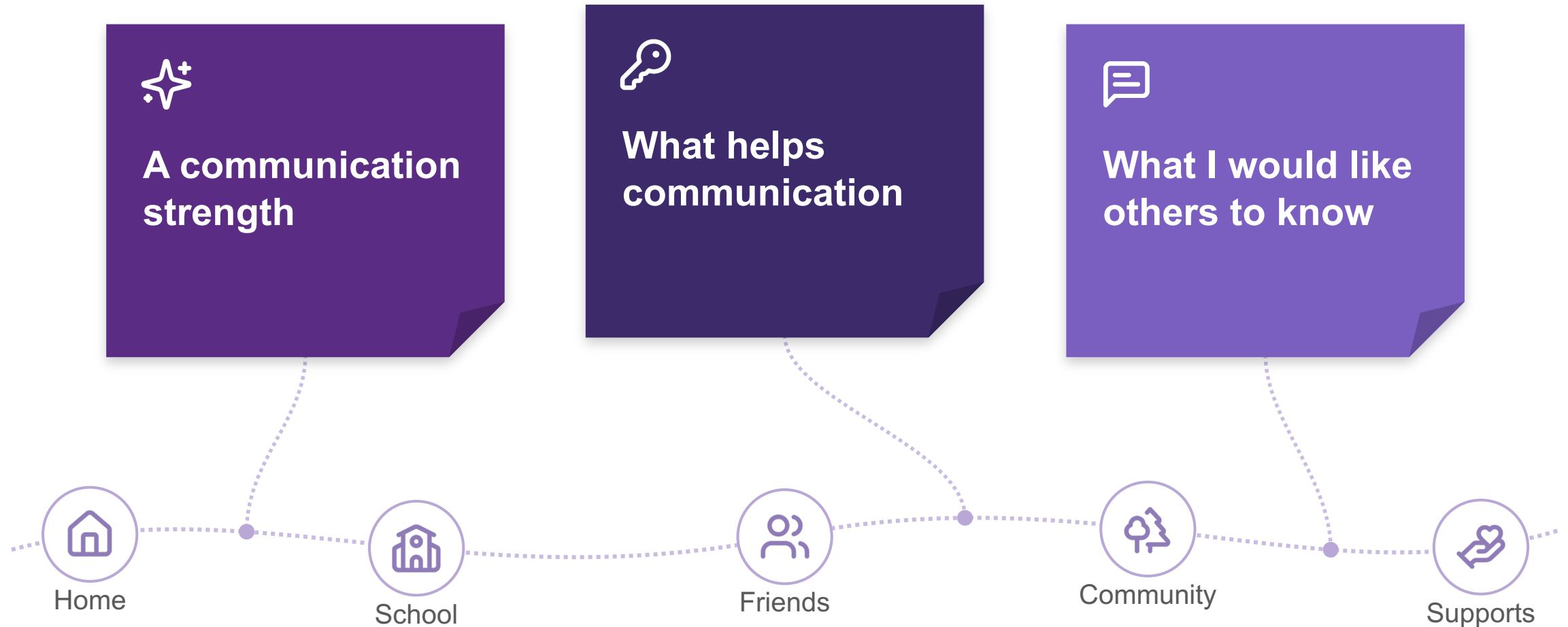
Who is part of the communication network?



Add one person or place.

You can return to the rest later.

What should travel between people and places?



How can we support communication?

1

CLEAR COMMUNICATION

Use familiar words.
One idea or step at a time.

2

PROCESSING TIME

Pause. Give time to
understand and respond.

3

VISUAL SUPPORTS

Show information as well
as saying it.

The right support depends on the person and the moment.

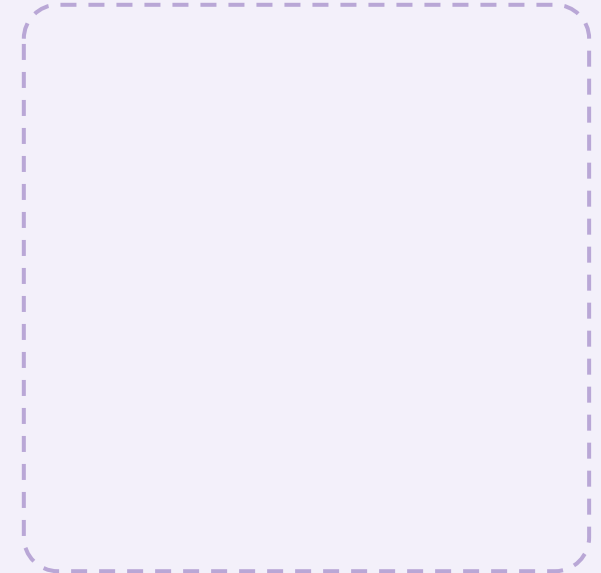
What are visual supports?



How much time is left?



What do I do next?

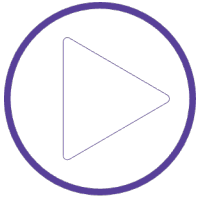


What is happening today?

Information you can see and come back to.

Double Empathy





Being social



Social Interactions

Family

School

Community

Online

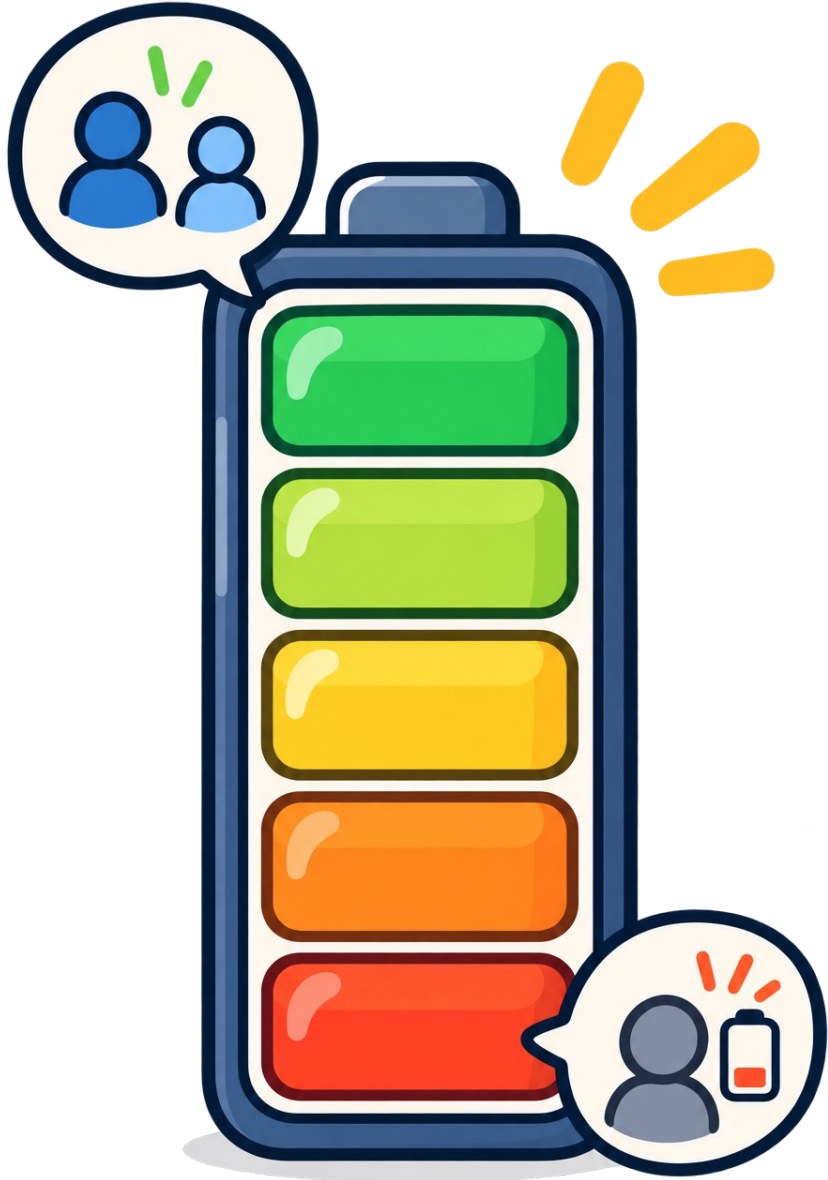


Discussion activity



- When do the students you have in mind seem most comfortable connecting with others at school?
- What kinds of connection does each of them enjoy?
(Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)
- Are there times in the school day when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?
- What can educators change to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?





Managing Daily Capacity

Batteries and Spoons

Think of a student's energy as a battery.

Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day.

Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, the body will show it.



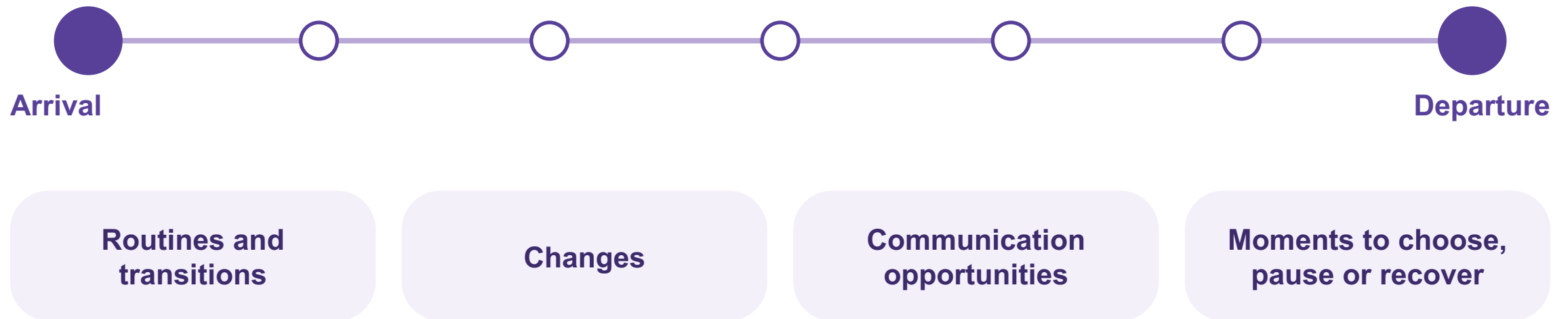
Fluctuating Capacity



Map a primary school day

Map a typical day in your classroom, from arrival to departure.

Draw a simple timeline, then add the moments that matter in your setting. Then mark how the same moments land for each of the students you have in mind.



What costs? What lightens?

Return to the day map.

Costs

What adds demand or uncertainty?

Lightens

What reduces demand?

What restores capacity or brings joy?

Where is a student's experience unknown?

Record questions rather than claiming to know an internal state.

The school-day stack

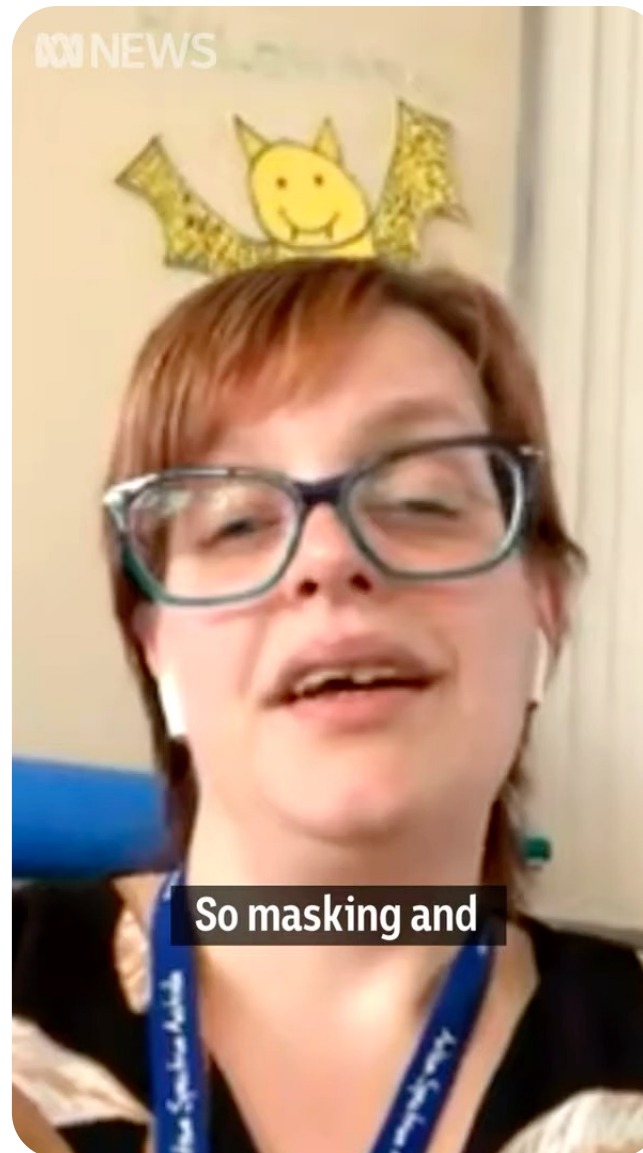
Notice what accumulates across the whole day.

A moment that seems small in isolation may sit within many demands. Include supports, relief and recovery as well as cost.





Masking



Masking and the cost of appearing fine



Discussion activity



- When might one of the students you have in mind be working hard to appear “fine” at school when they are not?
- When and where at school do they seem most comfortable being themselves?
- What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Audit your classroom's daily rhythms

What is the rhythm or routine, what may its impact be, and why?

- 1 Name the rhythm or routine.
- 2 Write what educators can observe without interpretation.
- 3 List possible environmental or task contributors.
- 4 Record what lightens demand and one question to investigate.

Classroom rhythm:

The repeated pattern and pace of learning, interaction, movement, transitions, demands and opportunities for pause or recovery across the school day.

Carry into design

Choose a clear focus for the next session.

Keep

One rhythm to keep
because it supports
access, connection or
joy

Reduce

One barrier or
unnecessary demand to
reduce

Explore

One question to explore
with students, families
or the team

Keep students first.

Positive Autistic Identity

A child who knows who they are -
and feels genuinely valued for it -
has more available for everything
else.

